

Why It Is Important to Study God's Word

Twelve Biblical Reasons

These twelve reasons are drawn straight from Scripture and set out along the lines the Reformed confessions have always followed. Each one stands on its own, but together they make a single point: God has spoken, and everything we most need — to be saved, to be made holy, to be comforted, to be kept from error — comes to us through what He has said.

1. Because it is the only place God has promised to make Himself savingly known

“And the LORD appeared again in Shiloh: for the LORD revealed himself to Samuel in Shiloh by the word of the LORD.” (1 Samuel 3:21)

“And this is life eternal, that they might know thee the only true God, and Jesus Christ, whom thou hast sent.” (John 17:3)

God is infinite and we are finite; He is holy and we are fallen. He cannot be reached by speculation, only received by revelation. And He has chosen one instrument: His Word. Notice that in 1 Samuel the LORD “appeared” — and the mode of His appearing was the word.

Creation truly displays God (Psalm 19:1; Romans 1:20), but it is enough to leave us without excuse, not enough to save. As the Westminster Confession puts it, the light of nature is “not sufficient to give that knowledge of God, and of His will, which is necessary unto salvation ... which maketh the holy Scripture to be most necessary.”

So when we say we are seeking God, we should be honest: God is not hiding. He has spoken, and He has published His speech. To seek Him while neglecting His Word is to refuse the very means He appointed.

2. Because the Spirit uses the Word as the instrument of the new birth

“Being born again, not of corruptible seed, but of incorruptible, by the word of God, which liveth and abideth for ever.” (1 Peter 1:23)

“Of his own will begat he us with the word of truth.” (James 1:18)

New birth is God's sovereign work — “of his own will” — but He has appointed a means, and the means is His Word. This is why the doctrines of grace never make Bible study optional. God ordains the means as surely as He ordains the end.

The Westminster Larger Catechism gathers it into one sentence: the Spirit makes the reading, but especially the preaching, of the Word an effectual means of “enlightening, convincing, and humbling sinners; of driving them out of themselves, and drawing them unto Christ; of conforming them to his image ... and establishing their hearts in holiness and comfort through faith unto salvation.”

Ten saving works — and the Spirit performs every one of them through the Word. He is not a second route to God that bypasses the Bible; He is the One who makes the Bible effectual.

3. Because saving faith itself is created by the Word

“So then faith cometh by hearing, and hearing by the word of God.” (Romans 10:17)

Paul’s argument in Romans 10 runs backwards like a chain: calling on the Lord requires believing, believing requires hearing, hearing requires a preacher. Remove the Word and the whole chain collapses.

This carries a very practical comfort. If your faith feels thin, the remedy is not to dig around inside yourself looking for more of it. Faith is not self-generated; it comes by hearing. Put yourself under the Word — read it, hear it preached, memorise it — and faith grows in the soil where God planted it.

4. Because Scripture alone is the final rule of faith and life

“To the law and to the testimony: if they speak not according to this word, it is because there is no light in them.” (Isaiah 8:20)

“These were more noble ... in that they received the word with all readiness of mind, and searched the scriptures daily, whether those things were so.” (Acts 17:11)

The Bereans were commended for checking an apostle against the Scriptures. Luke calls that noble. It is a remarkable endorsement of ordinary believers studying the Bible for themselves.

If Scripture is the only infallible rule, then ignorance of Scripture is ignorance of the standard by which everything else — every sermon, every book, every strong impression — must be measured. And there is no neutral ground here. A Christian who does not study the Bible has not escaped being formed by something; he has simply let a preacher, a tradition, a feeling, or a culture take the Bible’s place without noticing.

5. Because Scripture is the appointed instrument of sanctification

“Sanctify them through thy truth: thy word is truth.” (John 17:17)

“Thy word have I hid in mine heart, that I might not sin against thee.” (Psalm 119:11)

“But we all, with open face beholding as in a glass the glory of the Lord, are changed into the same image from glory to glory.” (2 Corinthians 3:18)

On the night before He died, the Son of God asked His Father to make His people holy — and He asked for it by means of the Word.

That last verse is the engine of the whole Christian life: we become what we behold. Holiness is not mainly a matter of gritting our teeth and trying harder; it is the slow work of sustained, believing sight of the glory of Christ. And that sight is mediated to us in Scripture. The Bible is the mirror in which He is seen.

This is why John Owen's famous charge — "Be killing sin or it will be killing you" — is not a call to raw willpower. Owen insisted that "all other ways of mortification are vain ... it must be done by the Spirit." And the Spirit's instrument is the Word. A believer who does not study Scripture has disarmed himself in the one war he cannot avoid.

6. Because all of Scripture testifies of Christ

"And beginning at Moses and all the prophets, he expounded unto them in all the scriptures the things concerning himself." (Luke 24:27)

"Search the scriptures ... they are they which testify of me." (John 5:39)

The Bible is not an anthology of moral lessons or a gallery of heroes to imitate. It is one book, by one Author, telling one story, about one Saviour. From Genesis to Revelation it is a single unfolding covenant of grace.

Calvin wrote that we should read the Scriptures with the aim of finding Christ in them, and that whoever turns aside from this object will never reach the knowledge of the truth, however hard he labours all his life.

So David and Goliath is not mainly about facing your giants. It is about a covenant king who fights the enemy on behalf of a people who cannot fight, and whose victory is counted as theirs. Read this way, every part of the Bible becomes luminous — the sacrifices, the exile, the laments, the prophets — because all of it converges on the cross and the empty tomb.

7. Because the Word is the Christian's only offensive weapon

"And take the helmet of salvation, and the sword of the Spirit, which is the word of God." (Ephesians 6:17)

"For the word of God is quick, and powerful, and sharper than any twoedged sword." (Hebrews 4:12)

In Paul's armour of God every other piece is defensive — belt, breastplate, shoes, shield, helmet. Exactly one item is a weapon, and it is the Word. A Christian who does not know his Bible is a soldier holding an unloaded rifle.

Christ Himself set the pattern in the wilderness (Matthew 4). Three temptations, three answers, every one of them "It is written," and every one quoted from Deuteronomy — a single book of the Law that He plainly knew by heart.

And notice that Satan quotes Scripture too (Matthew 4:6, from Psalm 91). Misused Scripture is answered by better-known Scripture. That is a sober argument for depth rather than mere familiarity: shallow Bible knowledge is exactly what leaves a believer defenceless against a plausible misuse of a text.

8. Because Scripture is the ground of assurance and the fountain of comfort

"For whatsoever things were written aforetime were written for our learning, that we through patience and comfort of the scriptures might have hope." (Romans 15:4)

“These things have I written unto you that believe on the name of the Son of God; that ye may know that ye have eternal life.” (1 John 5:13)

“This is my comfort in my affliction: for thy word hath quickened me.” (Psalm 119:50)

John says plainly why he wrote: so that believers may know. Assurance is not meant to be a lucky temperament enjoyed by a few; it rests on what God has promised and sworn.

A Christian wrestling with doubt is not helped by being told to feel more assured. He is helped by being shown, in black and white, what God has committed Himself to. That is why the Heidelberg Catechism opens by asking “What is your only comfort in life and in death?” and answers with a paragraph of pure Scripture — that I am not my own but belong to my faithful Saviour, who has fully paid for all my sins and preserves me so that not a hair can fall from my head without my Father’s will.

That comfort is simply unavailable to someone who does not know the Book it comes from.

9. Because the Word is the church’s defence against error

“I know this, that after my departing shall grievous wolves enter in among you ... And now, brethren, I commend you to God, and to the word of his grace, which is able to build you up.” (Acts 20:29–32)

“For the time will come when they will not endure sound doctrine; but after their own lusts shall they heap to themselves teachers, having itching ears.” (2 Timothy 4:3)

Paul’s farewell at Miletus is striking. Facing the certainty of wolves, he commends the elders not to strategy, not to institutional power, not to personal charisma, but to “the word of his grace.” The Word is the immune system of the church.

Every generation is told that some new teaching has arrived which the Bible did not anticipate. The only defence that has ever worked is the one John gives: test the spirits (1 John 4:1). A congregation that has stopped studying Scripture cannot recognise a wolf, because it no longer knows what a shepherd sounds like.

10. Because the Word is spiritual food — and we starve without it

“Man doth not live by bread only, but by every word that proceedeth out of the mouth of the LORD doth man live.” (Deuteronomy 8:3)

“I have esteemed the words of his mouth more than my necessary food.” (Job 23:12)

“Thy words were found, and I did eat them; and thy word was unto me the joy and rejoicing of mine heart.” (Jeremiah 15:16)

The Bible’s own picture of itself is not medicine, taken when we feel unwell, nor a reference book, consulted when we are puzzled. It is food — daily, ordinary, and non-negotiable.

That is the answer to “I don’t feel like reading my Bible today.” We do not eat because we feel like eating. We eat because we will die if we don’t.

Spurgeon once described John Bunyan this way: “Prick him anywhere; and you will find that his blood is Bibline, the very essence of the Bible flows from him. He cannot speak without quoting a text, for his soul is full of the Word of God.” That is what a lifetime of feeding produces — not a man who consults the Bible, but a man in whose bloodstream it runs.

11. Because God commands it — and we will be judged by it

“This book of the law shall not depart out of thy mouth; but thou shalt meditate therein day and night, that thou mayest observe to do according to all that is written therein.” (Joshua 1:8)

“Study to shew thyself approved unto God, a workman that needeth not to be ashamed, rightly dividing the word of truth.” (2 Timothy 2:15)

“The word that I have spoken, the same shall judge him in the last day.” (John 12:48)

Bible study is not a devotional hobby for those who happen to enjoy reading. It is commanded, and commanded to everyone. The Westminster divines said so explicitly against every attempt to keep the Scriptures in clerical hands: “all sorts of people are bound to read it apart by themselves, and with their families: to which end, the holy Scriptures are to be translated out of the original into vulgar languages.”

“All sorts of people are bound.” That is the language of duty. And the closing clause — that the Bible must be put into the common tongue — is the whole Reformation in a single line. It is what William Tyndale was strangled and burned for in 1536, so that a boy behind a plough could read it.

12. Because the end of all Bible study is worship

“The law of the LORD is perfect, converting the soul ... More to be desired are they than gold, yea, than much fine gold: sweeter also than honey and the honeycomb.” (Psalm 19:7, 10)

“O how love I thy law! it is my meditation all the day.” (Psalm 119:97)

Everything above could be made to sound merely useful, as though the Bible were a tool for getting things. It is not. The last reason is that the study of God’s Word ends in God Himself — and therefore in joy.

Psalm 119 is 176 verses long, an acrostic running through the entire Hebrew alphabet, and nearly every verse names the Word of God. That is not an accident of editing; it is a deliberate monument. And its dominant note is not duty but delight.

J. I. Packer put the danger and the goal together in one line: “A little knowledge of God is worth more than a great deal of knowledge about him.” The aim of study is never to accumulate information about God. It is to see Him, to love Him, and to worship.

“The grass withereth, the flower fadeth: but the word of our God shall stand for ever.” (Isaiah 40:8)
Soli Deo gloria